DEITY OF THE HOLY SPIRIT
PNEUMATOLOGY

WEEK 7

The deity of the Holy Spirit is a foundational concept in Orthodox theology, established by the belief that the Spirit is not merely a force or influence, but a distinct person within the Godhead. In the Bible, this is supported through the Spirit's attributes, actions, and direct identification with God.

Direct Identification as God

The Bible frequently uses "God" and "Holy Spirit" interchangeably.

- ✓ Acts 5:3–4: When Ananias lies to the Holy Spirit, Peter explicitly tells him, "You have not lied just to human beings but to God.“
- ✓ 1 Corinthians 3:16: Paul writes that believers are "God’s temple" because the "Spirit of God dwells in you," equating the presence of the Spirit with the presence of God Himself.



Divine Works

The Spirit performs actions that only a divine being can accomplish:

- Creation: The Spirit "hovered over the waters" during the creation of the world.
- Regeneration: He is responsible for the "new birth" of believers (John 3:5-8).
- Inspiration of Scripture: Human authors spoke as they were "carried along by the Holy Spirit." (2 Peter 1:21).
- Resurrection: He played a role in the resurrection of Jesus (Romans 8:11).

Personhood (Not a "Force")

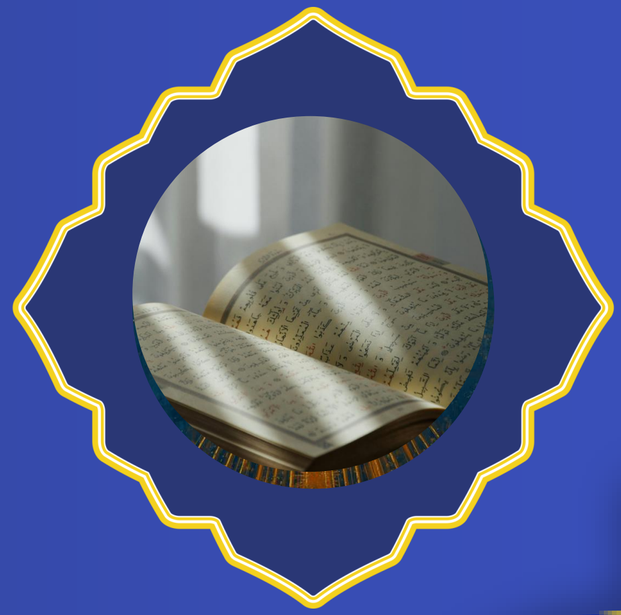
Critically, the Bible describes the Spirit as a Person with a will and emotions, rather than an impersonal energy:

He can be grieved: "And do not grieve the Holy Spirit of God..." (Ephesians 4:30).

He speaks and commands: He gives specific instructions to the apostles (Acts 13:2).

He intercedes: He prays on behalf of believers (Romans 8:26).

He has a will: He distributes spiritual gifts "to each one, just as he determines." (1 Corinthians 12:11).



Inclusion in the Trinity

The Holy Spirit is placed on equal footing with the Father and the Son in several key New Testament formulas:

The Great Commission: Jesus commands baptism in the name (singular) of the Father, the Son, and the Holy Spirit (Matthew 28:19).

The Apostolic Benediction: "May the grace of the Lord Jesus Christ, and the love of God, and the fellowship of the Holy Spirit be with you all." (2 Corinthians 13:14).



Early Church Fathers were instrumental in formalizing the doctrine of the Holy Spirit's deity. While the earliest writers (Apostolic Fathers) focused on the Spirit’s work in the church, the 4th-century "Pneumatomachians" (Spirit-fighters) challenged the Spirit's divinity, prompting the Fathers to provide rigorous biblical and logical defenses

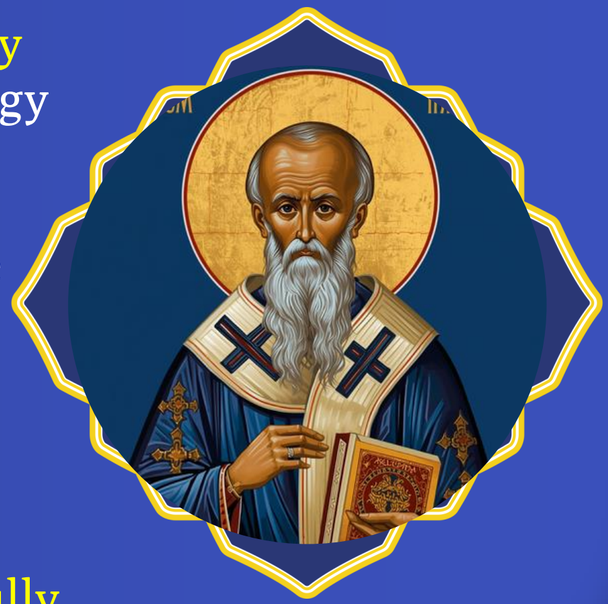
Pre-Nicene Fathers (Prior to 325 AD)

Before the great ecumenical councils, these writers laid the groundwork by treating the Spirit as an object of worship alongside the Father and Son.

- Ignatius of Antioch (c. 35–107 AD): He spoke of the Spirit as being part of the "divine order," comparing the Father to a builder and the Spirit to the rope that pulls the believer toward the "crane" (Christ).
- Justin Martyr (c. 100–165 AD): In his First Apology, he stated that Christians worship the Father, the Son in the "second place," and the "Prophetic Spirit in the third order.“
- Tertullian (c. 155–220 AD): The first to use the term Trinity (Trinitas). He famously described the Spirit as being "of one substance" (unius substantiae) with the Father and the Son, illustrating the relationship as a root, a tree, and its fruit.

Pneumatology of St. Athanasius of Alexandria

Pneumatology (doctrine of the Holy Spirit) of Athanasius of Alexandria is not as extensively developed as his Christology, but it is nonetheless foundational for later Trinitarian theology especially in defending the full divinity of the Holy Spirit.



1. **Context: Anti-Arian and Pro-Nicene Framework:-** Athanasius' theology is shaped by the conflict surrounding Arianism, which denied the full divinity of the Son and, by implication, subordinated the Spirit as well.

✓ His pneumatology emerges primarily in response to groups like the "Tropici," who questioned the Spirit's divine status.

2. The Spirit as Fully Divine:- Athanasius insists that the Holy Spirit is not a creature but fully divine, sharing in the same essence (ousia) as the Father and the Son.

✓ Though he does not use later technical language like **"consubstantial"** for the Spirit as explicitly as for the Son, his logic strongly implies it.

✓ The Spirit is inseparable from the Son, just as the Son is from the Father.

✓ The Spirit participates in divine operations such as sanctification and illumination activities that only God can perform.

3. Spirit's Role in Salvation:- for Athanasius, the Spirit is essential in the process of theosis (deification), a key theme in his theology:

- Humans are united to God through the Spirit.
- Spirit communicates the life of the Son to believers.
- Without the Spirit, participation in divine life would be impossible.

✓ This reflects his broader soteriology: "God became man so that man might become god," and the Spirit is the agent who actualizes this transformation.

4. Scriptural Argumentation :- Athanasius grounds his pneumatology in Scripture:

✓ He interprets passages like Matthew 28:19 (Trinitarian baptism) to show the Spirit's equality with the Father and Son.

✓ He argues that if the Spirit were a creature, baptism "into" the Spirit would be inappropriate.



5. Letters to Serapion:- His most explicit treatment appears in the Letters to **Serapion**, where he directly confronts those denying the Spirit's divinity:

➢ The Spirit is from God and belongs to God's being.

➢ The Spirit is not external to the Trinity but intrinsic to it.

➢ He emphasizes the Spirit's role in making believers "partakers of the divine nature."



6. Unity of the Trinity:- Athanasius stresses the inseparability of the Trinity:

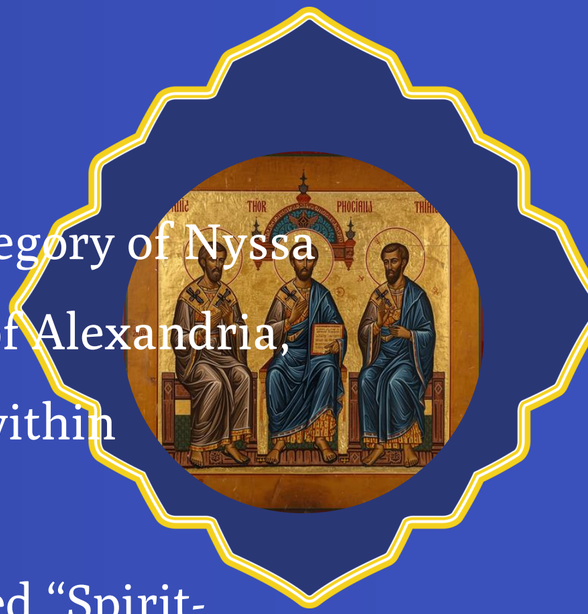
- ✓ There is one divine operation (energeia) shared by Father, Son, and Spirit.
- ✓ The Spirit is not an independent or lesser agent but works in perfect unity with the Father through the Son.

7. Influence on Later Theology:-Athanasius' pneumatology paved the way for later developments, especially in the work of the Cappadocian Fathers like Basil the Great, who would articulate more precise language about the Spirit's consubstantiality.

Summary Athanasius' pneumatology can be summarized as:

- ✓ High view of the Spirit's divinity
- ✓ Integration with Trinitarian unity
- ✓ Central role in salvation and deification
- ✓ Scripturally grounded and polemically driven

Pneumatology of Capadocian Fathers



Pneumatology of the Cappadocian Fathers Basil the Great, Gregory of Nazianzus, and Gregory of Nyssa is one of the decisive developments in early Christian theology. Building on Athanasius of Alexandria, they clarified and firmly established the full divinity and personhood of the Holy Spirit within Trinitarian doctrine.

- Historical Context: Pneumatomachian Controversy their work responds to the so-called "Spirit-fighters" (Pneumatomachians), who accepted the divinity of the Son but denied or minimized the divinity of the Holy Spirit an extension of Arianism. The Cappadocians aimed to show that:

✓ The Spirit is not a creature
✓ The Spirit is fully God, equal with the Father and the Son
✓ The Spirit is a distinct hypostasis (person)

- Full Divinity of the Holy Spirit:- Basil the Great in On the Holy Spirit, argues:

✓ The Spirit shares the same divine nature (ousia) as the Father and Son.
✓ The Spirit is included in worship and doxology ("with the Father and the Son together worshiped and glorified").
✓ Divine works (sanctification, life-giving) prove the Spirit's divinity.
❖ He avoids overly controversial terminology at times but clearly affirms equality



Gregory of Nazianzus :- Gregory is the most explicit:

- ✓ He openly calls the Spirit God.
- ✓ He argues that the Spirit must be either God or a creature and since the Spirit gives life and divinizes, He must be God.
- ✓ He emphasizes the progressive revelation of the Trinity: the Old Testament reveals the Father, the New reveals the Son, and the Church now fully recognizes the Spirit

Gregory of Nyssa:- Gregory develops a more philosophical account:

- ✓ The Spirit shares all divine attributes: eternity, holiness, power.
- ✓ The Spirit is inseparable in operation from the Father and the Son.
- ✓ He emphasizes the unity of divine action (μία ἐνέργεια) while maintaining three distinct persons



- The Spirit as a Distinct Person (Hypostasis):- Cappadocians made a crucial terminological clarification: One ousia (essence), three hypostases (persons). The Holy Spirit is:

✓ Not merely a force or energy

✓ Not subordinate or created

✓ A distinct person who proceeds from the Father (Gregory of Nazianzus especially emphasizes this)This formulation became foundational for later orthodoxy.

- Role in Salvation (Soteriology):- The Cappadocians deepen the link between pneumatology and salvation:

✓ The Spirit sanctifies and deifies (theosis)

✓ The Spirit unites believers to Christ

✓ The Spirit enables knowledge of God. Gregory of Nazianzus famously argues: `“If the Spirit is not to be worshiped, how can He deify me through baptism?

- Liturgical and Experiential Dimension:- Their theology is not abstract it is grounded in worship:



✓ The Spirit is invoked in baptism and Eucharist

✓ Christian prayer and doxology include the Spirit

✓ The Spirit is experienced as the one who transforms and illumines believers

- Trinitarian Unity and Order:- They articulate a balanced view:

Unity: One divine essence and one operation

Distinction: Father = unbegotten source

Son = begotten

Spirit = proceeding from the Father

❑ This avoids both modalism (collapsing distinctions) and subordinationism.

Legacy: Council of Constantinople (381):- Their theology directly influenced the expansion of the Nicene Creed at the First Council of Constantinople, which affirmed:

✓ The Holy Spirit as “Lord and giver of life”

✓ The Spirit as worshiped and glorified with the Father and the Son

The Cappadocian Fathers

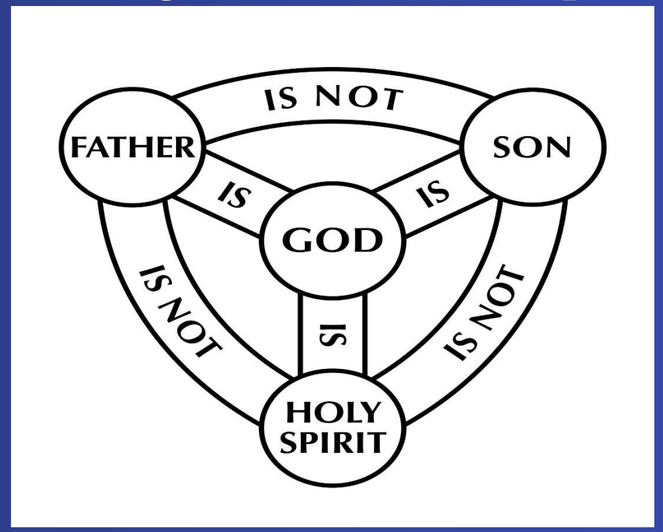
This trio was responsible for the language used in the Nicene-Constantinopolitan Creed (381 AD).



- Basil the Great: Wrote On the Holy Spirit. He argued that because the Spirit is joined with the Father and Son in baptism, He must be joined with them in glory (homotimos).

- Gregory of Nazianzus: He was the most explicit, boldly calling the Spirit "God." He argued that the Spirit's divinity was revealed progressively in redemptive history: the Father in the OT, the Son in the NT, and the Spirit's deity in the life of the Church.

- Gregory of Nyssa: He focused on the unity of the "divine operation," arguing that every act of God begins with the Father, proceeds through the Son, and is perfected by the Holy Spirit



CHURCH FATHERS ON DEITY



“የሦስቱ አካላት መለኮት ፍጹም አንድነትን ልናዉቅ ይገባናል፤የእነርሱ የሚሆን አንድ መለኮትን አንድ በማድረግ እናዋሕድ” ሃ አበዉ ዘቅዱስ ባስልዮስ32፡5

“ሥላሴ ክቡርምስጉን ነዉ፤በአካላት ሦስት ናቸዉ፤መለኮት አንድ ነዉ ስልጣን አንድ ነዉ ፈቃድ አንድ ነዉ የመለኮት ገንዘብ የሚሆን ባሕርይ አንድ ነዉ” ሃ. አበዉ ዘብንያሚ 94፡2

“በስም ሦስት ናቸዉ እንላለን አብ ወልድ መንፈስ ቅዱስ አንድ ባሕርይ አንድ ሥልጣን፡በመለኮት አንድ በባሕርይ አንድነት የጸኑ ሠስት አካላት ሲሆኑ ከሦስቱ አንዱ የሚበልጥ አንዱ የሚያንስ አይደለም በማይመረመር በአንድ ክብር የተካከሉ ናቸዉ እንጅ።” ሃ.አበዉ ዘጎርጎርዮስ60፡7

“ከአካላትም አንዱም አንዱ ከባሕርያቸዉ አይለወጡም አብ ወልድን መንፈስ ቅዱስን ለመሆን አይለወጥም፡ወልድም አብን መንፈስ ቅዱስን ለመሆን አይለወጥም፡መንፈስ ቅዱስም አብን ወልድን ለመሆን አይለወጥም” ሃ.አበዉ ዘቅዱስ ጎርጎርዮስ 60፡9

“ከሐዲዎች የሰባልዮስ ወገኖች እንደሚናገሩት አንድ አካል አይደለም፤አንድ መለኮት ሦስት አካላት ያሉት ነዉ እንጅ አብ አብ ነዉና፡ወልድም ወልድ ነዉና መንፈስ ቅዱስም መንፈስ ቅዱስ ነዉና።አብ ከወልድ ከመንፈስ ቅዱስ ተለይቶ አንዲት ሰዓት እንደ ዓይን ጥቅሻ ያህልስንኪ አልነበረም፡ሁልጊዜ ከነርሱ ጋር የነበረ የሚኖር ነዉ እንጅ።“ ሃ.አበዉ ዘቅዱስ አበዉ 33ክፍል5፡4-5

“እኛስ ሥስቱ በሦስትነት እንዳሉ እናምናለን ሥስትነታቸዉም በባሕርይ በመለኮት አይደለም በተለዩ አካላት ነዉ እንጅ፤ክህደቱ የጸና ስሙ የከፋ አርዮስ እንደሚታመናቸዉ አረማዉያን እንደሚያመልኪቸዉ ብዙ አማልክት አሉ ከማለት ፈጽመን እንራቅ ዳግመኛም ጵኑዓን አካላት በየራሰቸዉ እንዳሉ እናምናለን” ሃ. አበዉ ዘቅዱስ ዘቴወዶጦስ 92:4

“አብ በአካሉ በገጹ በመልኩ ያለነዉና፤ወልድም እንዲሁ በአካሉ በገጹ በመልኩ ያለ ነዉና፤መንፈስ ቅዱስም እንዲሁ በአካሉ በገጹ በመልኩ ያለ ነዉና እንደሰዉም አይወሰኑም፤አምላክነት ያላቸዉ አካላት ናቸዉና" ሃ. አበዉ ዘቅዱስ አትናቴዎስ 26፡3

“ዳግመኛም በየስማቸዉ በየገጻቸዉ ሥስቱን አካላት እንወቅ፡ከመለኮት ባሕርይ የተለየ አካል የለም፡በአካላትም በማይመረመር ክብር መለያየት የለም፤የሥስቱ ሥልጣን፡የሥስቱ ፈቃድ አንድ ነዉ እንጅ" ሃ.አበዉ ዘቅዱስ ጎርጎርዮስ 60፡5

“በአካላት ሥስት ሀላዌ፤በመለኮት አንድ ሀላዌ ናቸዉ ሃማኖታችን ይህ ነዉ ሐዋርያት በሰበሰቧት በቅድስት ቤተክርስትን ያገኘነዉ ድኅነታችን ይህ ነዉ" ሃ.አበዉ ዘቅዱስ ባስልዮስ 34፡22

“ይህ ሥስትነት በገጽ፤በአካል፤በመልክ ቀዳማዊ ነዉ አብን እናዉቀዋለን፤አብ በገጹ በአካሉ በመልኩ ያለ ፍጹም የባሕርይ አምላክ እንደሆነ ነገር ግን አይመረመርም መጸሕፍት እንደመሰከሩ፡ወልድን እናዉቀዋለን ወልድ በገጹ በአካሉ በመልኩ ያለ ፍጹም የባሕርይ አምላክ እንደሆነ፤ከአብ ባሕርይ የተገኘ ነዉ ስለአብ የተናገርነዉ ሁሉ ገንዘቡ ነዉ፤ያለርሱ ሌላ አባትን አያዉቅም፤ከሥስቱ አካል አንዱ አካል በአካሉ በመልኩ በሁሉ ፍጹም ነዉ።መንፈስቅዱስን እናዉቀዋለንመንፈስ ቅዱስ እንደአብ እንደወልድ እንደ ባሕርያቸዉ ገናንነት በገጹ በአካሉ በመልኩ ያለ ፍጹም የባሕርይ አምላክ እንደሆነ" ሃ.አበዉ ዘቅዱስ አትናቴዎስ28፡ 12-14

“አብ ወልድን መንፈስ ቅዱስን ወደመሆን አይለወጥም፤ወልድም አብን መንፈስ ቅዱስን ወደመሆን አይለወጥም፡መንፈስ ቅዱስምአብንወልድን ወደመሆን አይለወጥም።እሊህ ሥስቱ አካላት በጌትነት በክብር ፍጹማን ናቸዉ፤በአንድ መለኮት አንድነትም አንጂ ናቸዉ" ሃ.አበዉ ዘአግናጥዮስ11፡8



Haymanote Abew

In the book Haymanote Abew (Faith of the Fathers), various Church Fathers have taught extensively about the divine nature and work of the Holy Spirit. Here are some of the prominent Fathers and their teachings:

St. Athanasius (the Apostolic)

In responding to those who claimed the Holy Spirit was a created being, St. Athanasius stated:

- ✓ Divinity: "The Holy Spirit is not a creature; He is God who proceeds (emanates) from the Father.“
- ✓ Unity: He strongly taught that the Holy Spirit is one with the Father and the Son in nature, will, and authority. He said, "The Trinity is one, indivisible in glory and nature."

St. Cyril (the Scholar of Alexandria)

In explaining the relationship between the Holy Spirit and the Son, St. Cyril said:

- ✓ Leading light of the Apostles (ሐዋርያት ሞሪ): "The Holy Spirit is the true God who gave wisdom and power to the Apostles and performs the mysteries within the Church."
- ✓ Sanctification: He described the Spirit as the one who cleanses humanity from sin and grants us of God (the gift of sonship-ሀብተ ወልድናን).

Haymanote Abew

St. Gregory (the Theologian):- Known for writing extensively on the mystery of the Trinity, St. Gregory said:

- ✓ Luminosity: "The Father is light, the Son is light, and the Holy Spirit is light; yet they are not three lights, but one light."
- ✓ Hypostatic Property (ግብር): He explained that the Holy Spirit is "the one who proceeds" (emanating from the Father), and this personal property distinguishes Him from the other Persons (Hypostases).

St. Basil (of Caesarea) :- Regarding the honor due to the Holy Spirit, St. Basil stated:

- ✓ Deity: "He is God, worthy of being worshiped and glorified together with the Father and the Son.“
- ✓ Creator: Citing Psalm 33:6 ("By the word of the Lord the heavens were made, and all their host by the breath [Spirit] of His mouth"), he taught that the Holy Spirit was present with the Father and the Son in the work of creation.

St. Dionysius: Describes the Holy Spirit as the "Source of Life" who gives life to all.

St. John Chrysostom: Teaches that the Holy Spirit is the "Comforter" who instills the love of God in the hearts of human beings.

In conclusion, all these Fathers teach with one voice that the Holy Spirit is not a creature but the Creator God who is equal to the Father and the Son.

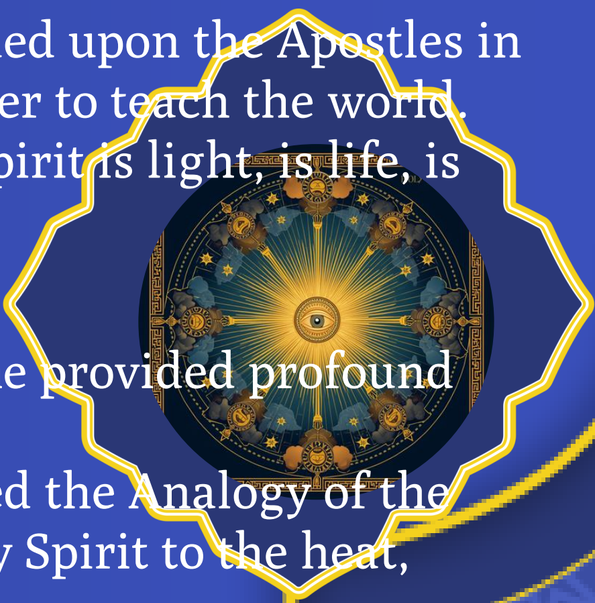
Ethiopian Fathers

The teachings of the scholars of the Ethiopian Orthodox Tewahedo Church (Ethiopian Fathers) regarding the Holy Spirit are presented extensively, based on scholarly interpretations and the hagiographies of St. Yared.

The following are the main points taught by Ethiopian Fathers about the Holy Spirit:

St. Yared :- In his compositions (especially in the Deggua), St. Yared speaks of the mystery of the Holy Spirit as follows:

- ✓ Steward of the New [Covenant] መጋቤ ሐዲስ: He explains that the Holy Spirit descended upon the Apostles in the Upper Room (Tsirha Tsion), revealed languages to them, and gave them the power to teach the world.
- ✓ Light and Life ብርሃን ወሕይወት፡- He praises Him in his melodies, saying, "The Holy Spirit is light, is life, is peace." the Spirit is food and light for the soul.



Abba Giyorgis of Gascha :-In his great book, Metsehafe Mestir (The Book of Mystery), he provided profound teachings on the Holy Spirit:

- ✓ Procession (Sirtset): To explain that the Holy Spirit proceeds from the Father, he used the Analogy of the Sun: comparing the Father to the sun's circle-ክበብ, the Son to the light, and the Holy Spirit to the heat, illustrating their Trinity and Unity.
- ✓ Not a Creature: While heretics of his time claimed the Holy Spirit was a created being, he used Biblical evidence to argue and confirm His divinity and His consubstantiality (oneness in nature) with the Father and the Son.

Ethiopian Scholars (In Commentaries):- In the interpretations of Haymanote Abew, our country's scholars clarify the following mysteries:



- ✓ Giver of Life: The Holy Spirit is called "Life" because He is the one who grants life to all living things.
- ✓ Person (Akal) and divine Energeia : They firmly teach that the Holy Spirit has a perfect Person, a perfect form, and a perfect face, and that His personal property is "Procession" (Sirtset).
- ✓ Work in the Church Mysteries: They explain that it is the Holy Spirit who grants sonship in Baptism and who transforms (treats/sanctifies) the bread and wine into the Divine Body and Divine Blood during the Eucharist.

Liturgy (Qidase)

Holy Spirit within the Liturgy (Qidase) is central and profound. The Holy Spirit is presented as the "Sanctifier" (Qadash) and the "Transformer" (the one who changes the bread and wine).

Epiclesis (Prayer of Invocation):- most awe-inspiring part of the Liturgy. The priest extends his hands over the bread and wine, praying for the Holy Spirit to descend and transform the bread into the Divine Body and the wine into the Divine Blood.

- ✓ Prayer: "Send the Holy Spirit upon us to make this bread the Body of Christ and this cup the Blood of Christ.“
- ✓ Meaning: It demonstrates that the Mystery is performed not by human power, but through the divine operation of the Holy Spirit.

In the Creed (O Creed):- During the Nicene Creed, recited communally during the Liturgy, the identity of the Holy Spirit is declared:

- ✓ "We believe in the Holy Spirit, the Lord, the Giver of Life, who proceeds from the Father.“
- ✓ "With the Father and the Son, He is worshipped and glorified.“
- ✓ "He is the one who spoke through the prophets."

Anaphora of Epiphany



Attributes of the Holy Spirit

Within the Liturgy, wonderful names are used to describe the Holy Spirit:

- ✓ "Spirit of Righteousness" (Spirit of Truth): The one who reveals the truth to humanity.
- ✓ “Spirit of Power" : The one who strengthens the weak.
- ✓ "Paraclete" (Comforter/Advocate): The one who serves as a helper to the Church in times of sorrow and trial.

His Work Upon the Faithful

St. Epiphanius describes the benefits the Holy Spirit grants to those who receive the Holy Body and Blood:

- ✓ Illumination of the Heart (Berhane Lebuna): He enlightens the mind and heart.
- ✓ Remission of Sins: He acts as the "remover of sin" (granting forgiveness).
- ✓ Strengthening Spiritual Love: He is described as the one who solidifies divine love within the believer.

Desert Fathers

The teachings of the Desert Fathers (the Abbas and Ammas) regarding the Holy Spirit are rooted in practice and experience rather than mere theory. To them, knowing the Holy Spirit was not about debating His nature, but about being transformed by His "fire."

"Become All Flame“:- one of the most famous stories from the desert. Abba Lot went to Abba Joseph and said, "I pray, I fast, and I purify my heart as much as I can; what more should I do?"

- ✓ Abba Joseph stood up and stretched his hands toward heaven; his ten fingers shone like ten lamps of fire.
- ✓ He then said: "If you will, you can become all flame."
- ❖ It teaches that Christianity is not just about fulfilling a few rules, but about being transformed by the fire of the Holy Spirit to become "divine fire" itself.



Purity of Heart and the Holy Spirit:- Fathers often compared the Holy Spirit to the light of the sun.

- ✓ The sun is always shining; however, if the house (the heart) is choked with filth and smoke (sin), the light cannot enter.
- ✓ "asceticism" (fasting, prayer, humility) is not needed to create the Holy Spirit, but to remove the dirt within us so that the light of the Holy Spirit can become visible.

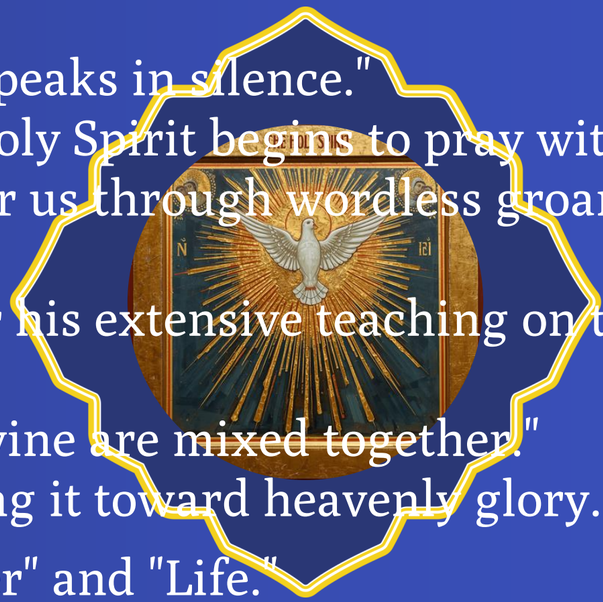
Desert Fathers

Grace of Discernment (Diakrisis) :- Among all the gifts of the Holy Spirit, the Desert Fathers highly prized "the grace of discernment" (the ability to distinguish between spirits).

- ✓ St. Anthony the Great said, "Discernment is greater than all other virtues.“
- ✓ This is the divine wisdom that helps a person distinguish between thoughts coming from the Holy Spirit and those coming from one's self or the enemy.

Silence and the Holy Spirit :- Fathers believed that "the Holy Spirit speaks in silence."

- ✓ When a person stills their speech and thoughts (Hesychia), the Holy Spirit begins to pray within their heart.
- ✓ They put into practice the verse: "The Spirit himself intercedes for us through wordless groans" (Romans 8:26).



Kidus. Macarius the Great:- is a leader among the Desert Fathers for his extensive teaching on the Holy Spirit. In his homilies, he says:

- ✓ "The soul must be united with the Holy Spirit, just as water and wine are mixed together."
- ✓ He teaches that the Holy Spirit is the "chariot" of the soul, carrying it toward heavenly glory.

The teachings of the Desert Fathers present the Holy Spirit as "Power" and "Life."

- ✓ They focus on "Knowledge of the Heart" rather than academic knowledge.
- ✓ To them, the Holy Spirit means "the warmth felt during prayer, the endurance given during trials, and the love revealed in the presence of enemies."

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